



Heart Rate Recovery

Lowering elevated resting heart rate through nutrition, nervous system regulation, and daily protocol

Dr. Vera Holloway, CNS + CHN · Your Health Matters

Resting heart rate is the most telling number you can measure about your nervous system.

A persistently elevated resting heart rate (above 80 BPM) signals that the sympathetic nervous system is overworking — even at rest. This is reversible. With targeted nutrition, vagal nerve activation, and daily protocols, resting HR can drop 5-15 BPM within 2-6 weeks measurably.

RESTING HEART RATE — UNDERSTANDING THE ZONES

< 60 BPM	60-70 BPM	70-80 BPM	80-90 BPM	> 90 BPM
ATHLETIC	OPTIMAL	ACCEPTABLE	ELEVATED	CONCERN
Conditioned heart · strong parasympathetic tone · seen in well-trained athletes	Healthy nervous system balance · ideal range for most adults	Within normal range but room for improvement	Sympathetic dominance · stress signal · address with protocol	Chronic stress activation · seek physician evaluation alongside protocol

■ Magnesium

How it works: Relaxes vascular smooth muscle · supports parasympathetic tone · regulates cardiac contractions

Dose: Magnesium glycinate 400mg before bed · OR magnesium taurate 300-500mg with dinner

Food sources: Pumpkin seeds (1oz) · spinach · Swiss chard · almonds · avocado · dark chocolate 70%+ · black beans

■ Potassium

How it works: Balances sodium · supports proper heart rhythm · reduces vascular constriction

Dose: 3,500-4,700mg daily from food · not supplements (unless physician supervised)

Food sources: Avocado (1 whole = 700mg) · sweet potato · spinach cooked · white beans · salmon · coconut water

■ Omega-3 EPA/DHA

How it works: Reduces inflammation · stabilizes heart rhythm · lowers triglycerides · supports vagal tone

Dose: Fish oil 1000-2000mg combined EPA+DHA daily · WITH food for absorption

Food sources: Wild salmon · sardines · anchovies · mackerel · walnuts · flaxseed · chia seeds

■ Beet Juice

How it works: Natural nitrates → nitric oxide · vasodilation · improved blood flow · lower HR workload

Dose: 8oz fresh beet juice daily (morning Peak Zone) · pair with healthy fat for absorption

Food sources: Fresh beets · beet greens · arugula · spinach · pomegranate · watermelon

■ Hawthorn Berry

How it works: Strengthens cardiac muscle · dilates coronary arteries · proven HR reduction in studies

Dose: Hawthorn extract 500mg 2x daily · standardized to 1.8% vitexin · consult MD if on heart meds

Food sources: Hawthorn berry tea · 1-2 cups daily · also available as tincture or capsule

■ Hibiscus Tea

How it works: Natural ACE inhibitor · lowers blood pressure · reduces sympathetic activity

Dose: 2-3 cups daily · 1 tsp dried hibiscus per cup · steeped 5-10 minutes · cooled or warm

Food sources: Pure hibiscus tea · pomegranate · cherries · green tea · chamomile (also calming)

The vagus nerve is your body's built-in heart rate brake. Activating it directly drops HR within seconds-to-minutes. These 4 techniques are clinically proven, free, and available anytime.

■ 4-7-8 Breathing

How: Inhale through nose 4 counts · Hold 7 counts · Exhale through mouth 8 counts · Repeat 4 cycles

When: When you notice elevated HR · before sleep · during anxiety waves · 3-5 times daily

Effect: Drops HR 5-15 BPM within 60-90 seconds

* Cold Water Reset

How: Splash cold water on face for 30 seconds OR submerge face in bowl of ice water 15-30 seconds

When: When HR is elevated and you need fast results · also helpful for acute anxiety

Effect: Activates mammalian dive reflex · drops HR within seconds

■ Humming + Gargling

How: Hum any tune for 1-2 minutes · OR gargle water vigorously for 30 seconds

When: Mornings while in shower · during quiet moments · before stressful events

Effect: Vibrates the vagus nerve directly · increases vagal tone over time

■ Outdoor Walking

How: 10-20 minutes outside · no phone · peripheral vision (look at trees, sky, horizon)

When: Daily · ideally after meals · especially mid-afternoon when cortisol typically rises

Effect: Drops cortisol 15-20% · lowers HR · improves HRV measurably

TIME	ACTION
6-7am wake	16oz water + sea salt + lemon · 4-7-8 breathing 4 cycles · Cold water face splash
Breakfast	Eggs + spinach + avocado + pumpkin seeds · Magnesium-rich foods
Mid-morning	Fresh beet juice 8oz (Peak Zone) · Outdoor walk 10-15 min
Lunch	Wild salmon or sardines · leafy greens · sweet potato · post-meal walk 10 min
Afternoon	Hibiscus tea · 5-min stretch break · pause practice
Dinner (before 6:30pm)	Light dinner · vegetable soup or salad · no caffeine after noon
Evening	Hawthorn berry tea · 4-7-8 breathing · gentle stretching
Before bed (9:30pm)	Magnesium glycinate 400mg · chamomile tea · room temperature 65-68°F
Sleep	In bed by 10:30pm · phone in another room · 7-8 hours sleep

REALISTIC RECOVERY TIMELINE — WHAT TO EXPECT

Days 1-3

You begin to feel calmer. Sleep improves. HR may drop 2-5 BPM.

Week 1

Resting HR drops 5-10 BPM. HRV begins to improve. Energy more stable.

Week 2-3

Resting HR continues to fall. Sleep quality measurably better. Anxiety waves less frequent.

Week 4-6

New baseline establishing. HR typically 10-15 BPM lower than starting point.

Month 2-3

Sustained low resting HR · improved HRV · much higher resilience to stress

WHAT RAISES HEART RATE — WHAT TO REMOVE

■ Caffeine

Especially after noon · stays in system 6-8 hours · directly stimulates sympathetic system

■ Alcohol

Initially sedating but raises HR overnight · disrupts REM sleep · dehydrates

■ Refined sugar

Triggers cortisol response · blood sugar swings raise HR

■ Poor sleep

Single night under 6 hours raises next-day HR 5-10 BPM

■ Dehydration

Blood volume drops · heart compensates by beating faster

■ Sympathetic stress

Chronic worry-thoughts firing the cascade multiple times daily

■ Sedentary lifestyle

Untrained heart needs more beats to do the same work

■ Hidden infections

UTIs, dental issues, gut imbalances all raise resting HR · get checked if HR is unexplained

***Dr. Vera:** Your heart is a muscle that responds to everything your body does — what you eat, how you breathe, what you think, how you sleep. An elevated resting heart rate is not a personal failing. It is a signal. Your nervous system is asking for help. Listen to it. Feed it. Breathe with it. Walk with it. Sleep deeply for it. Within weeks your heart will respond — not because you forced it — because you finally gave it what it needed.*